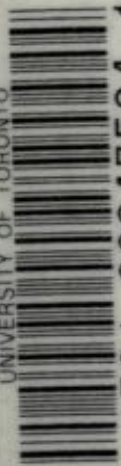


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# FRIENDS

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WILFRID WILSON GIBSON





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WILFRID WILSON GIBSON

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# FRIENDS

BY  
WILFRID WILSON GIBSON

LONDON  
ELKIN MATHEWS, CORK STREET  
M CM XVI

*BY THE SAME WRITER*

(Uniform with FRIENDS)

BATTLE (1915).

THOROUGHFARES (1914).

BORDERLANDS (1914).

FIRES (1912).

DAILY BREAD (1910).

AKRA THE SLAVE (1910).

STONEFOLDS (1907).

TO THE MEMORY  
OF  
RUPERT BROOKE

*He's gone.  
I do not understand.  
I only know  
That as he turned to go  
And waved his hand  
In his young eyes a sudden glory shone:  
And I was dazzled by a sunset glow.  
And he was gone.*

23rd April, 1915.

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## RUPERT BROOKE

### I.

Your face was lifted to the golden sky  
Ablaze beyond the black roofs of the square,  
As flame on flame leapt, flourishing in air  
Its tumult of red stars exultantly,  
To the cold constellations dim and high;  
And as we neared, the roaring ruddy flare

Kindled to gold your throat and brow and hair  
Until you burned, a flame of ecstasy.

The golden head goes down into the night  
Quenched in cold gloom--and yet again you stand  
Beside me now with lifted face alight,  
As, flame to flame, and fire to fire you burn...  
Then, recollecting, laughingly you turn,  
And look into my eyes and take my hand.

## II.

Once in my garret--you being far away  
Tramping the hills and breathing upland air,  
Or so I fancied--brooding in my chair,  
I watched the London sunshine feeble and grey  
Dapple my desk, too tired to labour more,  
When, looking up, I saw you standing there,  
Although I'd caught no footstep on the stair,  
Like sudden April at my open door.

Though now beyond earth's farthest hills you fare,  
Song-crowned, immortal, sometimes it seems to me  
That, if I listen very quietly,  
Perhaps I'll hear a light foot on the stair,  
And see you, standing with your angel air,

Fresh from the uplands of eternity.

### III.

Your eyes rejoiced in colour's ecstasy  
Fulfilling even their uttermost desire,  
When, over a great sunlit field afire  
With windy poppies, streaming like a sea  
Of scarlet flame that flaunted riotously  
Among green orchards of that western shire,  
You gazed as though your heart could never tire  
Of life's red flood in summer revelry.

And as I watched you little thought had I  
How soon beneath the dim low-drifting sky  
Your soul should wander down the darkling way,  
With eyes that peer a little wistfully,  
Half-glad, half-sad, remembering, as they see  
Lethan poppies, shrivelling ashen grey.

### IV.

October chestnuts showered their perishing gold  
Over us as beside the stream we lay



In the Old Vicarage garden that blue day,  
Talking of verse and all the manifold  
Delights a little net of words may hold,  
While in the sunlight water-voles at play  
Dived under a trailing crimson bramble-spray,  
And walnuts thudded ripe on soft black mould.

Your soul goes down unto a darker stream  
Alone, O friend, yet even in death's deep night  
Your eyes may grow accustomed to the dark,  
And Styx for you may have the ripple and gleam  
Of your familiar river, and Charon's bark  
Tarry by that old garden of your delight.

WILLIAM DENIS BROWNE

(GALLIPOLI, 1915)

Night after night we two together heard  
The music of the Ring,  
The inmost silence of our being stirred  
By voice and string.

Though I to-night in silence sit, and you  
In stranger silence sleep,

Eternal music stirs and thrills anew  
The severing deep.

## TENANTS

Suddenly, out of dark and leafy ways,  
We came upon the little house asleep  
In cold blind stillness, shadowless and deep,  
In the white magic of the full moon-blaze.  
Strangers without the gate, we stood agaze,  
Fearful to break that quiet, and to creep  
Into the home that had been ours to keep  
Through a long year of happy nights and days

So unfamiliar in the white moon-gleam,  
So old and ghostly like a house of dream  
It seemed, that over us there stole the dread  
That even as we watched it, side by side,  
The ghosts of lovers, who had lived and died  
Within its walls, were sleeping in our bed.

## SEA-CHANGE

Wind-flicked and ruddy her young body glowed  
In sunny shallows, splashing them to spray;  
But when on rippled, silver sand she lay,  
And over her the little green waves flowed,  
Coldly translucent and moon-coloured showed  
Her frail young beauty, as if rapt away  
From all the light and laughter of the day  
To some twilit, forlorn sea-god's abode.

Again into the sun with happy cry  
She leapt alive and sparkling from the sea,  
Sprinkling white spray against the hot blue sky,  
A laughing girl ... and yet, I see her lie  
Under a deeper tide eternally  
In cold moon-coloured immortality.

## GOLD

All day the mallet thudded, far below  
My garret, in an old ramshackle shed  
Where ceaselessly, with stiffly nodding head  
And rigid motions ever to and fro  
A figure like a puppet in a show  
Before the window moved till day was dead,

Beating out gold to earn his daily bread,  
Beating out thin fine gold-leaf blow on blow.

And I within my garret all day long  
Unto that ceaseless thudding tuned my song,  
Beating out golden words in tune and time  
To that dull thudding, rhyme on golden rhyme.  
But in my dreams all night in that dark shed  
With aching arms I beat fine gold for bread.

## THE OLD BED

Streaming beneath the eaves, the sunset light  
Turns the white walls and ceiling to pure gold,  
And gold, the quilt and pillows on the old  
Fourposter bed--all day a cold drift-white--  
As if, in a gold casket glistening bright,  
The gleam of winter sunshine sought to hold  
The sleeping child safe from the dark and cold  
And creeping shadows of the coming night.

Slowly it fades: and stealing through the gloom  
Home-coming shadows throng the quiet room,  
Grey ghosts that move unrustling, without breath,  
To their familiar rest, and closer creep

About the little dreamless child asleep  
Upon the bed of bridal, birth and death.

## TREES

(*To LASCELLES ABERCROMBIE*)

The flames half lit the cavernous mystery  
Of the over-arching elm that loomed profound  
And mountainous above us, from the ground  
Soaring to midnight stars majestically,  
As, under the shelter of that ageless tree  
In a rapt dreaming circle we lay around  
The crackling faggots, listening to the sound  
Of old words moving in new harmony.

And as you read, before our wondering eyes  
Arose another tree of mighty girth--  
Crested with stars though rooted in the earth,  
Its heavy-foliaged branches, lit with gleams  
Of ruddy firelight and the light of dreams--  
Soaring immortal to eternal skies.



## OBLIVION

Near the great pyramid, unshadowed, white,  
With apex piercing the white noon-day blaze,  
Swathed in white robes beneath the blinding rays  
Lie sleeping Bedouins drenched in white-hot light.  
About them, searing to the tingling sight  
Swims the white dazzle of the desert ways  
Where the sense shudders, witless and adaze,  
In a white void with neither depth nor height.

Within the black core of the pyramid  
Beneath the weight of sunless centuries  
Lapt in dead night King Cheops lies asleep;  
Yet in the darkness of his chamber hid  
He knows no black oblivion more deep  
Than that blind white oblivion of noon skies.

## RETREAT

Broken, bewildered by the long retreat  
Across the stifling leagues of southern plain,  
Across the scorching leagues of trampled grain,  
Half-stunned, half-blinded, by the trudge of feet

And dusty smother of the August heat,  
He dreamt of flowers in an English lane,  
Of hedgerow flowers glistening after rain--  
All-heal and willow-herb and meadow-sweet.

All-heal and willow-herb and meadow-sweet--  
The innocent names kept up a cool refrain--  
All-heal and willow-herb and meadow-sweet,  
Chiming and tinkling in his aching brain,  
Until he babbled like a child again--  
"All-heal and willow-herb and meadow-sweet."

## COLOUR

A blue-black Nubian plucking oranges  
At Jaffa by a sea of malachite  
In red tarboosh, green sash, and flowing white  
Burnous--among the shadowy memories  
That haunt me yet by these bleak northern seas  
He lives for ever in my eyes' delight,  
Bizarre, superb in young immortal might--  
A god of old barbaric mysteries.

Maybe he lived a life of lies and lust:  
Maybe his bones are now but scattered dust

Yet, for a moment he was life supreme  
Exultant and unchallenged: and my rhyme  
Would set him safely out of reach of time  
In that old heaven where things are what they seem.

## NIGHT

Vesuvius, purple under purple skies  
Beyond the purple, still, unrippling sea;  
Sheer amber lightning, streaming ceaselessly  
From heaven to earth, dazzling bewildered eyes  
With all the terror of beauty; thus day dies  
That dawned in blue, unclouded innocence;  
And thus we look our last on Italy  
That soon, obscured by night, behind us lies.

And night descends on us, tempestuous night,  
Night, torn with terror, as we sail the deep,  
And like a cataract down a mountain-steep  
Pours, loud with thunder, that red perilous fire...  
Yet shall the dawn, O land of our desire,  
Show thee again, re-orient, crowned with light!

## THE ORPHANS

At five o'clock one April morn  
    I met them making tracks,  
Young Benjamin and Abel Horn,  
    With bundles on their backs.

Young Benjamin is seventy-five,  
    Young Abel, seventy-seven--  
The oldest innocents alive  
    Beneath that April heaven.

I asked them why they trudged about  
    With crabby looks and sour--  
"And does your mother know you're out  
    At this unearthly hour?"

They stopped: and scowling up at me  
    Each shook a grizzled head,  
And swore; and then spat bitterly,  
    As with one voice they said:

"Homeless, about the country-side  
    We never thought to roam;  
But mother, she has gone and died,  
    And broken up the home."

## THE PESSIMIST

His body bulged with puppies--little eyes  
    Peeped out of every pocket, black and bright;  
And with as innocent, round-eyed surprise  
    He watched the glittering traffic of the night.

"What this world's coming to I cannot tell,"  
    He muttered, as I passed him, with a whine--  
"Things surely must be making slap for hell,  
    When no one wants these little dogs of mine."

?

Mooning in the moonlight  
    I met a mottled pig,  
Grubbing mast and acorn,  
    On the Gallows Rigg.

"Tell, oh, tell me truly,  
    While I wander blind,  
Do your peepy pig's eyes

Really see the wind--

"See the great wind flowing  
Darkling and agleam,  
Through the fields of heaven,  
In a crystal stream?

"Do the singing eddies  
Break on bough and twig,  
Into silvery sparkles  
For your eyes, O pig?

"Do celestial surges  
Sweep across the night,  
Like a sea of glory  
In your blessed sight?

"Tell, oh, tell me truly!"  
But the mottled pig  
Grubbing mast and acorns  
Did not care a fig.

## THE SWEET-TOOTH

Taking a turn after tea

Through orchards of Mirabelea,  
Where clusters of yellow and red  
Dangled and glowed overhead,  
Who should I see  
But old Timothy,  
Hale and hearty as hearty could be--  
Timothy under a crab-apple tree.

His blue eyes twinkling at me,  
Munching and crunching with glee,  
And wagging his wicked old head,  
"I've still got a sweet-tooth," he said.  
"A hundred and three  
Come January,  
I've one tooth left in my head," said he--  
Timothy under the crab-apple tree.

## GIRL'S SONG

I saw three black pigs riding  
In a blue and yellow cart--  
Three black pigs riding to the fair  
Behind the old grey dappled mare--  
But it wasn't black pigs riding  
In a gay and gaudy cart

That sent me into hiding  
With a flutter in my heart.

I heard the cart returning,  
The jolting jingling cart--  
Returning empty from the fair  
Behind the old jog-trotting mare--  
But it wasn't the returning  
Of a clattering, empty cart  
That sent the hot blood burning  
And throbbing through my heart

## THE ICE CART

Perched on my city office-stool,  
I watched with envy, while a cool  
And lucky carter handled ice...  
And I was wandering in a trice,  
Far from the grey and grimy heat  
Of that intolerable street,  
O'er sapphire berg and emerald floe,  
Beneath the still, cold ruby glow  
Of everlasting Polar night,  
Bewildered by the queer half-light,  
Until I stumbled, unawares,



Upon a creek where big white bears  
Plunged headlong down with flourished heels,  
And floundered after shining seals  
Through shivering seas of blinding blue.  
And as I watched them, ere I knew,  
I'd stripped, and I was swimming, too,  
Among the seal-pack, young and hale,  
And thrusting on with threshing tail,  
With twist and twirl and sudden leap  
Through crackling ice and salty deep--  
Diving and doubling with my kind,  
Until, at last, we left behind  
Those big, white, blundering bulks of death,  
And lay, at length, with panting breath  
Upon a far untravelled floe,  
Beneath a gentle drift of snow--  
Snow drifting gently, fine and white,  
Out of the endless Polar night,  
Falling and falling evermore  
Upon that far untravelled shore,  
Till I was buried fathoms deep  
Beneath that cold white drifting sleep--  
Sleep drifting deep,  
Deep drifting sleep...

The carter cracked a sudden whip:  
I clutched my stool with startled grip,  
Awakening to the grimy heat

Of that intolerable street.

TO E. M.

(IN MEMORY OF R. B.)

The night we saw the stacks of timber blaze  
To terrible golden fury, young and strong  
He watched between us with dream-dazzled gaze  
Aflame, and burning like a god of song,  
As we together stood against the throng  
Drawn from the midnight of the city ways.

To-night the world about us is ablaze  
And he is dead, is dead ... Yet, young and strong  
He watches with us still with deathless gaze  
Aflame, and burning like a god of song,  
As we together stand against the throng  
Drawn from the bottomless midnight of hell's ways.

10th June, 1915.

## MARRIAGE

Going my way of old,  
Contented more or less,  
I dreamt not life could hold  
Such happiness.

I dreamt not that love's way  
Could keep the golden height  
Day after happy day,  
Night after night.

## ROSES

Red roses floating in a crystal bowl  
You bring, O love; and in your eyes I see,  
Blossom on blossom, your warm love of me  
Burning within the crystal of your soul--  
Red roses floating in a crystal bowl.

FOR G.

All night under the moon  
Plovers are flying  
Over the dreaming meadows of silvery light,  
Over the meadows of June,  
Flying and crying--  
Wandering voices of love in the hush of the night.

All night under the moon,  
Love, though we're lying  
Quietly under the thatch, in silvery light  
Over the meadows of June  
Together we're flying--  
Rapturous voices of love in the hush of the night.

1915

## HOME

### I. RETURN

Under the brown bird-haunted eaves of thatch  
The hollyhocks in crimson glory burned  
Against black timbers and old rosy brick,  
And over the green door in clusters thick  
Hung tangled passion-flowers, when we returned

To our own threshold: and with hand on latch  
We stood a moment in the sunset gleam  
And looked upon our home as in a dream.

Rapt in a golden glow of still delight  
Together on the threshold in the sun  
We stood rejoicing that we two had won  
To this deep golden peace ere day was done,  
That over gloomy plain and storm-swept height  
We two, O love, had won to home ere night.

## II. CANDLE-LIGHT

Where through the open window I could see  
The supper-table in the golden light  
Of tall white candles--brasses glinting bright  
On the black gleaming board, and crockery  
Coloured like gardens of old Araby--  
In your blue gown against the walls of white  
You stood adream, and in the starry night  
I felt strange loneliness steal over me.

You stood with eyes upon the candle flame  
That kindled your thick hair to burnished gold,  
As in a golden spell that seemed to hold  
My heart's love rapt from me for evermore...

And then you stirred, and opening the door,  
Into the starry night you breathed my name.

### III. FIRELIGHT

Against the curtained casement wind and sleet  
Rattle and thresh, while snug by our own fire  
In dear companionship that naught may tire  
We sit--you listening, sewing in your seat  
Half-dreaming in the glow of light and heat,  
I reading some old tale of love's desire  
That swept on gold wings to disaster dire  
Then rose re-orient from black defeat.

I close the book, and louder yet the storm  
Threshes without. Your busy hands are still;  
And on your face and hair the light is warm,  
As we sit gazing on the coals' red gleam  
In a gold glow of happiness, and dream  
Diviner dreams the years shall yet fulfil.

### IV. MIDNIGHT

Between the midnight pillars of black elms

The old moon hangs, a thin, cold, amber flame  
Over low ghostly mist: a lone snipe wheels  
Through shadowy moonshine, droning; and there steals  
Into my heart a fear without a name  
Out of primæval night's resurgent realms,  
Unearthly terror, chilling me with dread  
As I lie waking wide-eyed on the bed.

And then you turn towards me in your sleep  
Murmuring, and with a sigh of deep content  
You nestle to my breast and over me  
Steals the warm peace of you; and, all fear spent,  
I hold you to me sleeping quietly,  
Till I, too, sink in slumber sound and deep.

\* \* \* \* \*

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By Wilfrid Wilson Gibson

BATTLE. Crown 8vo. 1s. net. [*Third Thousand*]

### Some Extracts from early Press Notices

"With the exception of Rupert Brooke's five sonnets, '1914,' 'Battle' contains, we think, the only English poems about the war--so far--for which anyone would venture to predict a future on their own merits."--*The Athenæum*.

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means, we feel; these exquisite bodies insulted by agony and death, these incalculable spirits devastated. What all this destruction is for is taken for granted. Modern warfare is not beautiful, and Mr. Gibson does not try to gloss it in the usual way, by underlining the heroism and endurance it evokes. All that is simply assumed in these poems, just as the common soldier himself assumes it. An almost appalling heroism is unemphatically revealed in them as the fundamental fact of usual human nature. This is the ground-bass, and above its constancy plays the ever-varying truth of what fighting means to some individual piece of human nature. The poems are moments isolated and fixed out of the infinite changing flux of human reaction to the terrible galvanism of war. But that thrilling galvanism does not alter human kind; and sometimes Mr. Gibson forces us to realise the vast unreason of war by bringing into withering contact with its current a mind still preoccupied with the habits of peace."--MR. LASCELLES ABERCROMBIE in *The Quarterly Review*.

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"But, though these poems would have failed if their psychology had been plainly faulty, their worth as psychological documents is not the main thing about them. The main thing about them is just that they are extraordinary poems; by means of their psychology, no less and no more than by means of their metre, their rhyme, their intellectual form and their

concrete imagery, they pierce us with flashing understanding of what the war is and means--not merely what it is to these individual pieces of ordinary human nature who are injured by it and who yet dominate it, but, by evident implication, what the war is in itself, as a grisly multitudinous whole. It seems to us beyond question that Mr. Gibson's 'Battle' is one of the most remarkable results the war has had in literature."--*The Nation*.

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